COMMST 204: Today

1. **INTRODUCTION TO GROUPS AND TEAMS**

1. RECALL: COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZATIONAL CULTURE

- Edgar Schein: Organizational culture is “a pattern of shared basic assumptions that have been invented, discovered, or developed by a group as it learns to cope with problems of external adaptation and internal integration.”

- Visible in, for instance, the actions, stories, and artifacts that characterize an organization.
- Also characterized by values and assumptions.

Leaders can…

- Try to influence, build, or dismantle organizational cultures.

- Values
- Attitudes
- Ways of doing things

Whether they like it or not, though….

- Leaders must negotiate cultural realities.

Two Perspectives

- Deliberate creation of culture
- Organic, spontaneous emergence of culture

Groups and Teams

Groups and Teams

- A big part of how people experience organizations

Groups and Teams

- Can be more formal structures with rules, goals, and clear leadership structures.
- Can be less formal structures, in which norms, rules, and leaders emerge.
- Leadership will be assigned or emerge.

Advantages of groups and teams in the workplace

- Varied expertise
- Possible diversity
- Benefits of discussion and deliberation

Disadvantages

- Can be inefficient
- Require ongoing, effective communication
- Not all members buy in
- People can coast on others' efforts

- Require nurturing and care
- Require ongoing reflection by leaders and other members

- Good groups and teams can take advantage of individual skills and traits to achieve group goals.
- Tough to do

Example: Learning Groups (Ronald Adler, *Understanding Human Communication*, 339)

- "The purpose of a learning group is to increase the knowledge and skill of each member" (339).
- You are in one right now in this class!

Reflection

- Consider some challenges you have faced in your groupwork here at UW or in other educational contexts?
- What makes groupwork hard? What, if anything, makes it worth doing?

Self and other(s): interpersonal communication

- Individual satisfaction contributes to group and team satisfaction.
  - Good argument in favour of democracy in teams
- Authoritarianism, especially without the presence of coercive mechanisms, can lead to disengagement.

- Self-concept and esteem and other individual considerations affect groups and teams…

Recall: Self-concept

- “Your subjective description of who you think you are—it is filtered through your own perceptions” (Beebe, et al, 27).

- Not the same as how others perceive us.
- Remember to “decenter” or “perspective take” in group or team life.

Group member performance

- You have a group member who has done little work, tends not to communicate with you and your groupmates, and often drifts off in conversation. How annoying, eh?

- What might be behind this behaviour?

Recall: Self-esteem

- High or low?
  - **Low:** sensitive to affronts to one's views, difficulty contributing, reluctance to take chances
  - **High:** generally a "thicker skin," but possible unwillingness to incorporate others' views

Influence of previous experiences

- **Perceptions** of others are interpreted through the lens of previous experiences
  - What have you learned about group work from previous experiences?
  - What presumptions do you make about fellow students in your groups?
  - How do you tend to interpret your own behaviours?

Recall: perception

- Confirmation bias
- Self-serving bias
- Attribution problems
- Negotiation: discussion of what the things we witness mean
  - Factions

Member Roles in Groups and Teams

Task Role

- “Task guiding behaviors are those behaviors that initiate and maintain a productive task dimension during the group’s discussions.” (Fujishin, 119).

Maintenance Role ("Social-Guiding Behaviors")

- "Social-guiding behaviours encourage and maintain a healthy social dimension during group discussion" (123).

Self-centred Role (241)

- "A role with far less positive effects is the self-centered role—a team member who seeks to dominate the group's discussions and work or to divert the group's attention from serious issues by making them seem unimportant. The self-centered role is always considered inappropriate and unproductive" (Eisenberg, et al, *Organizational Communication*, 241).

Some roles on teams (Kenneth Benne and Paul Sheats, terms in bold as discussed in Fujishin)

Task Roles (+ve)	Maintenance Roles (+ve)	Self-Centered Roles (-ve)
Information requestor	**Encourager**	Negative blocker (contrarian)
Information giver	**Feeling expressor**	Dominator
Information clarifier	**Harmonizer**	Attacker
Discussion guider/summarizer	**Energizer**	Clown
Evidence analyzer/reasoning tester	Social supporter	Player
Negotiator	Tension reliever	Special interest pleader
Initiator, opinion giver, opinion requestor		

- When you get a chance, please watch a quick summary of roles that people play in groups and on teams from Alex Lyon from the State University of New York.

Reflection

- What roles to you play often and/or effectively?
- What roles might you adopt or improve in future?

Seeking Democracy in Small Groups

- Demos: “a useful shorthand term for a body of people who govern themselves democratically” (Gastil 15).

- A department in an organization
- A project group
- A community organization
- A team
- An artistic group
- A group of friends
- A family

Democracy versus Autocracy

Democratic	Autocratic (Authoritarian)
Equality of voices	Hierarchy of voices
Respect for all views (shared wisdom)	Little respect for views of less prominent members
Persuasion rather than compulsion	Rules, rewards, and punishments from the top
Decisions by consensus or vote	Decisions by leader(s)
Multidirectional communication	Downward communication
The group, rather than the leader, counts most.	The leader counts most.